Monsters of

There are hundreds of different species of squid. Some of them are as small as a coin. Others are as long as a bus. They have interesting names, like the jewel squid, the vampire squid, the flying squid, and the ram's horn squid. They also have interesting bodies.

Eight arms lined with hooks, suckers, and sucker rings or a combination of hooks and suckers

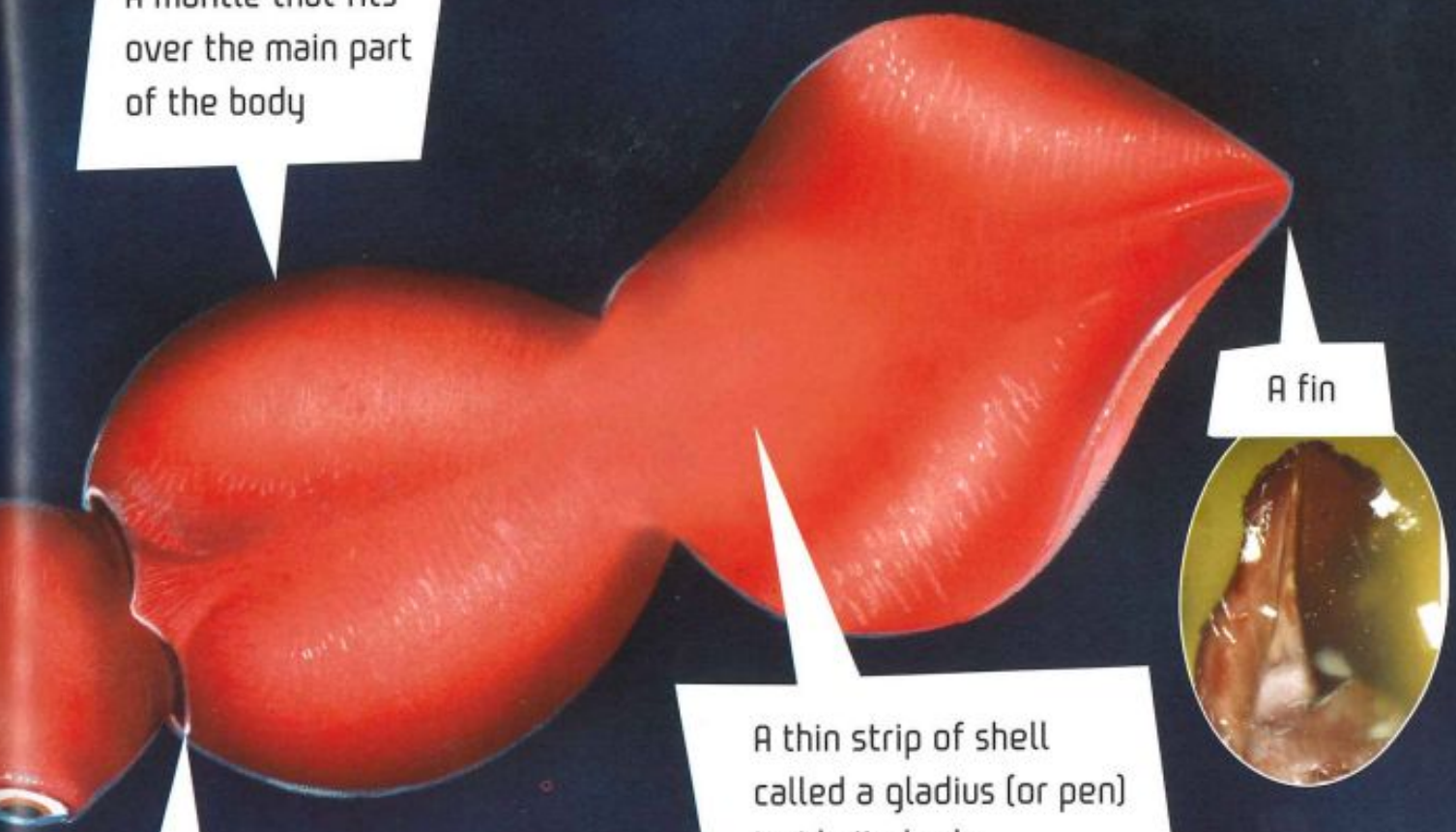
A head

Two tentacles with sharp, rotating hooks

A mouth with a strong curved beak at the centre of the circle of arms

the Deep

by Philippa Werry



Squid are members of the animal kingdom that belong to the phylum called Mollusca. Slugs, snails, oysters, and clams also belong to the mollusc phylum. Molluscs all have one thing in common. They are invertebrates, or animals without a backbone.

A squid uses its muscular mantle to suck water in and squirt it out again so that the squid shoots backwards like a torpedo.

Squid can change colour to attract a mate, scare enemies off, or hide, and they can squirt ink to help them get away without being seen.

There are many species of squid, and we know more about some of them than we do about others.

Giant squid

Belongs to the family Architeuthidae – giant squid

Long cylinder shape

6- to 7-metre-long tentacles

Short arms with rows of suckers (no hooks)

Weighs up to 275 kilograms (female) or 150 kilograms (male)

Lives in mid-depth water, from 200–1000 metres deep

Colossal squid

How big is big?

Two of the biggest squid are the giant squid (*Architeuthis dux*, or "king of the chief squid"), which is found around the New Zealand coast, and the colossal squid (*Mesonychoteuthis hamiltoni*), found in Antarctic waters.

Belongs to the family Cranchiidae – glass squid

Bigger, rounder, heavier body

2- to 3-metre-long tentacles

Short arms lined with hooks and suckers

Weighs up to 495 kilograms (and possibly more)

Huge fin on its back, small head, big eyes

Lives in very deep water, 1 000 or more metres deep

How many colossal squid have been captured?

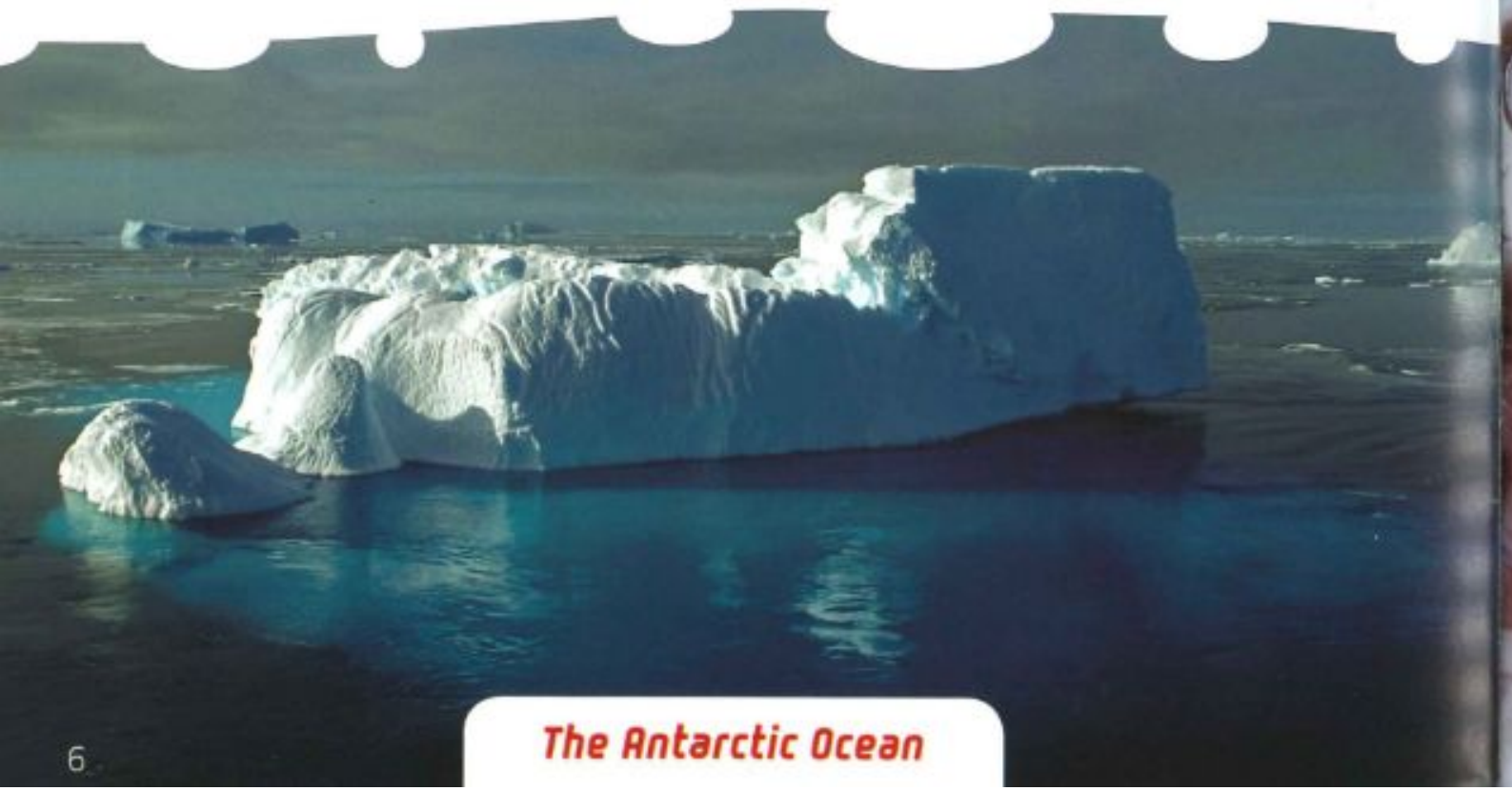
Sailors used to tell stories of monsters lurking in the ocean depths, but it wasn't till 1925 that parts of a colossal squid were discovered in the stomach of a sperm whale. This was the first time this squid had ever been seen. Very few adult colossal squid have been found since. Most have been found in the stomachs of sperm whales or caught in fishing nets, and usually they have been damaged or are in pieces.

Following the clues

Colossal squid live more than 1000 metres down in the near-freezing Antarctic Ocean. That's a kilometre under water!

Scientists have used underwater cameras to try to film these animals, but there is still a lot we don't know about them.

There are lots of questions that scientists want to find answers for. How do they swim? How fast can they travel? How do they hunt for food? How many of them are there? How do they mate? Why have more females than males been found? How big do they get? How long do they live?

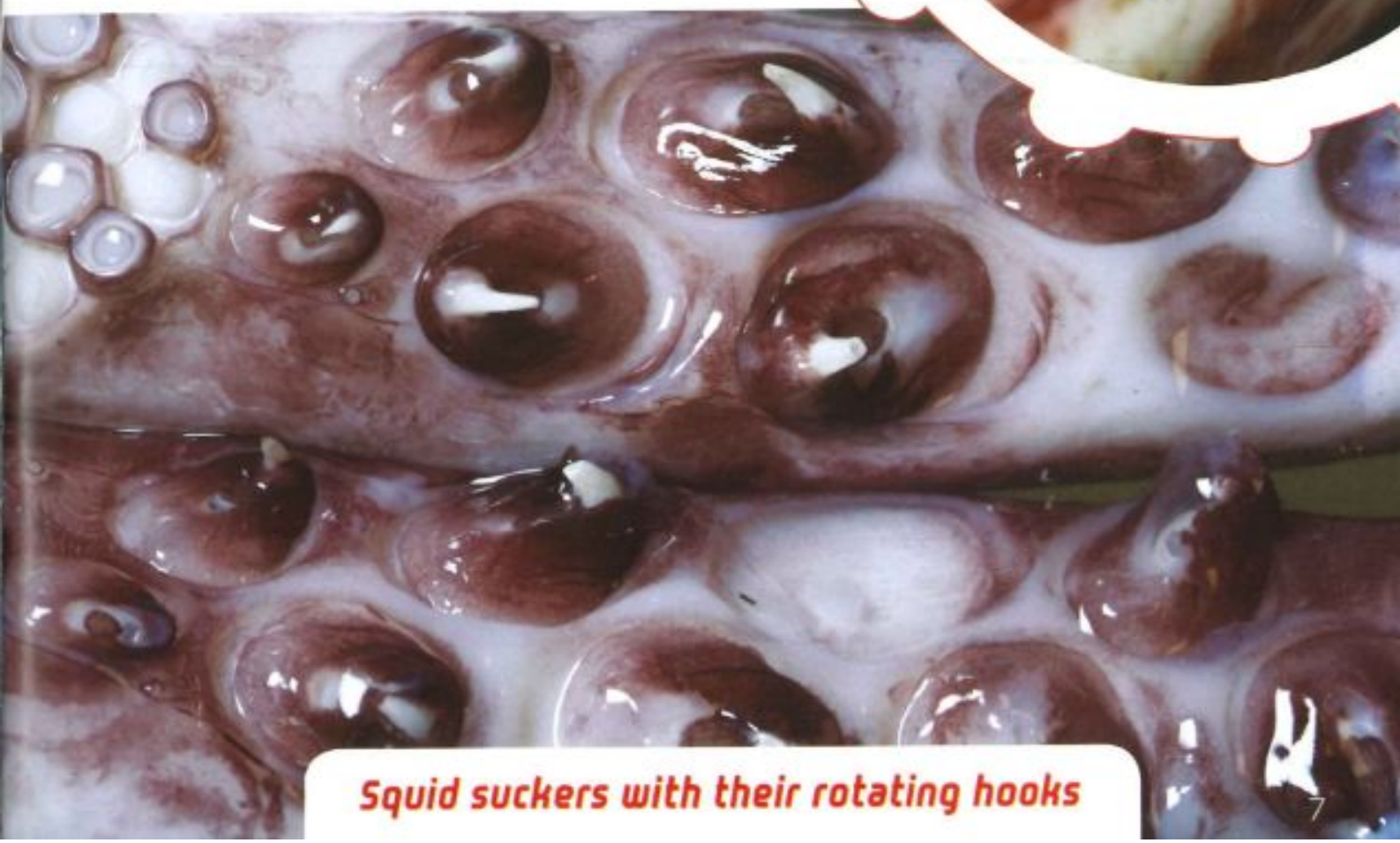


What do the scientists know?

Scientists work like detectives. They use all the information they have gathered from the few colossal squid that have been discovered to find out about their behaviour and their life deep down in the sea.

Here are some of the things they have been able to find out:

- The colossal squid is the largest squid species and the world's largest invertebrate.
- Its eyes can be approximately 30 centimetres in diameter – the size of dinner plates. They are the largest eyes we have ever seen.
- In the suckers at the tips of its tentacles, the colossal squid has sharp rotating hooks that can turn 360 degrees. It is probably a ferocious hunter.



Squid suckers with their rotating hooks

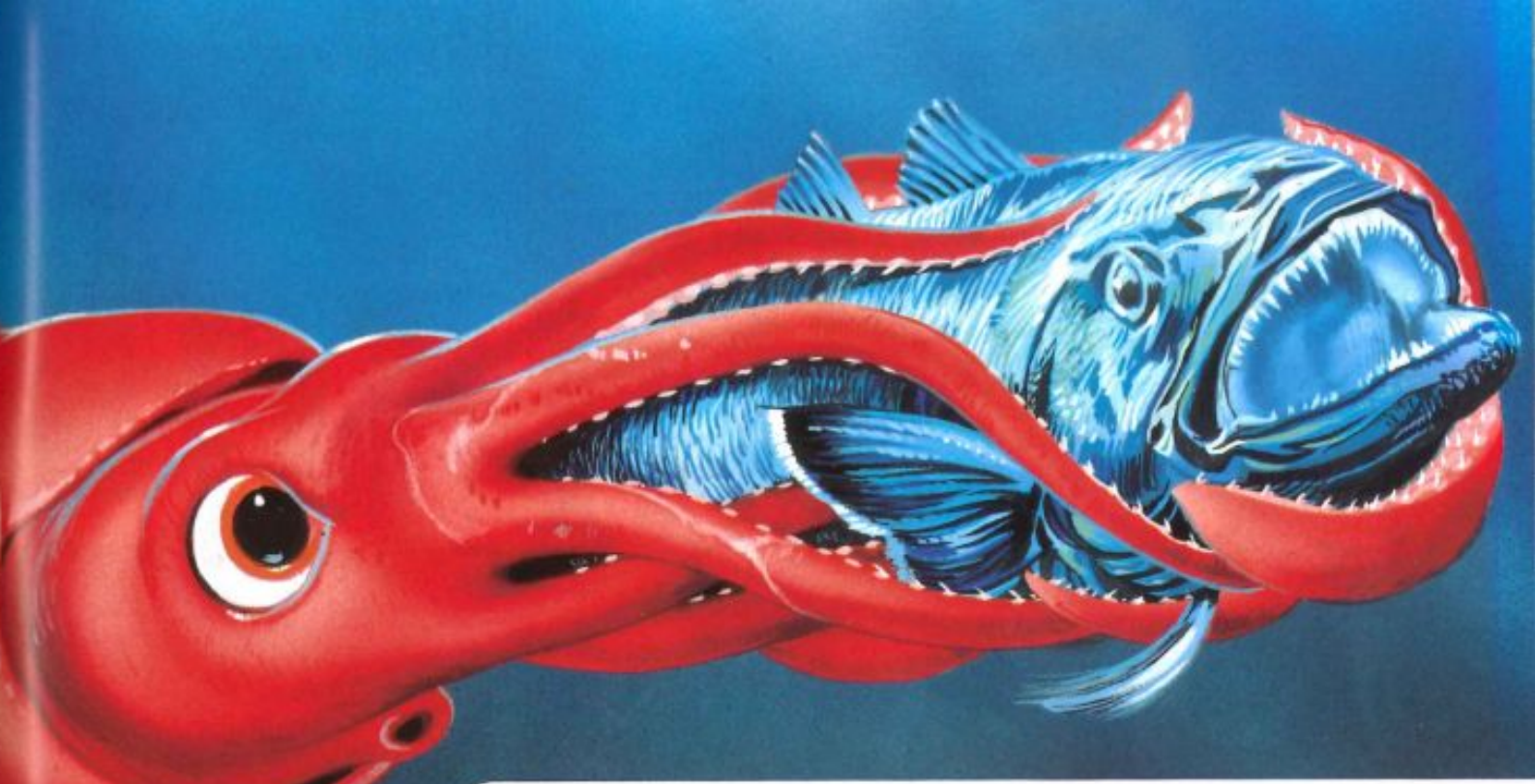
How do they eat?

The colossal squid probably eats big fish like the Antarctic toothfish and also other squid. It holds onto its prey with its tentacles and rips out chunks of flesh with its beak. Then it uses its radula, a hard rasping tongue covered with teeth, to chop the fish up even smaller.

What eats colossal squid?

When scientists examine the stomach contents of sperm whales, they often find the beaks of colossal squid. The beak is the only part of the squid that doesn't easily break down. Scientists think that colossal squid could make up 75 percent of a male sperm whale's diet. It could take as much as 1 tonne of squid per day to feed an adult sperm whale. That means there could be huge numbers of colossal squid in the southern oceans. Sperm whales often have marks and scars on their heads from the suckers and hooks of squid. Nobody has ever seen a battle between a sperm whale and a colossal squid, but it would be an incredible sight.

The deep sea is an enormous, unexplored habitat. Scientists are making new discoveries all the time, but there is still much they don't know. As marine biologist Steve O'Shea says, "Tomorrow something bigger, longer, never before seen might turn up."



A colossal squid catching an Antarctic toothfish

Squid beaks from a sperm whale's stomach